seemed to run effortlessly because someone was always holding it together. Her father, a scientist and strategic thinker, encouraged problem-solving and systems-level thinking. More importantly, he noticed something in her long before she noticed it herself. "He could tell I was good at bringing people together," she recalls. "He told me early on that I would be a leader." Her grandfather, who had turned completely blind in his 60s, lived with the family for a period of time and taught her the values of persistence and making the best of situations. Her grandmother taught her empathy, warmth, and the importance of celebrating the smaller things.

Years later, during a conversation about leadership, Malini's thoughts returned naturally to her mother. She describes her as deeply organised, the kind of person who woke before everyone else, made sure every detail was taken care of, and quietly kept life moving. "My mother was a role model. I got my organisational skills from her and learned the values of planning and execution. Direction is as important as your team seeing you in action," she says.

Then, almost overnight, everything changed. When her mother passed away, Malini found herself navigating new responsibilities. Until then, she had never needed to run a household. "I still remember my first day in the kitchen," she laughs. "The pressure cooker exploded." The memory is humorous now, but it marked the beginning of a much deeper lesson. There was no instruction manual, no transition period, and no opportunity to feel fully prepared. So, she learned the same way she would learn many things throughout her life, by doing, stumbling, adapting, and trying again.

If her parents shaped her values, her siblings shaped her character. Malini grew up surrounded by people who, in very different ways, helped make her the leader she is today. Her siblings gave her the balanced impetus she needed. "I'd see my sister studying till 2am and wonder if I could do it, so sustained, and yet creative. And my brother and I did music and tennis together and challenged each other to get better. He was also my biggest cheerleader during tournaments," she recalls.



Family photo

When she reflects on her childhood today, she does not see one defining influence, but rather a determination to learn the best from each of them. "I've learnt my management skills similarly at work by trying to learn the best from people around," Malini says.

Sport: From competition to concentration

Sport was a defining part of Malini's growth. In her teenage years, she played tennis and volleyball competitively. "I can't think of any week going by without play or exercise even now. It not only taught me consistency and hard work, but also how to compete, collaborate, fail gracefully, and recover," she says.

The boy she would marry

Some of the most important partnerships in Malini's life began long before she could have imagined where life would take her. What started as table tennis banter in high school eventually led her to her husband, Prakash. What stands out is not simply how young they were when they met, but the values they built together. Even during their undergraduate years, both were clear that they wanted to establish strong career foundations before making major life decisions.

Looking back, that understanding feels remarkably consistent with the qualities that would later define both their lives: logic, patience, and respect for each other's ambitions. Those qualities became even more important when her career eventually took the family to Canada. Away from the support systems that many families take for granted, life demanded a different kind of partnership. Parenting, daily responsibilities, and the challenges of building careers in a new environment had to be shared.

"He is very supportive and is always pushing me to grow, and I try to reciprocate. Balance has been our mantra while keeping the peace at home," she says.

No clear plan, just forward movement

After completing her studies, Malini entered unfamiliar territory. Her transition into her first role at National Semiconductor was far